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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

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Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Section Title(S): Hunger And Begging • Wage Labour

Some men remain away permanently. They are still a source of assistance to their kinsmen who seek them out in emergencies, but they contribute less than does the man who alternates between work and the Valley.

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Hunger and Begging

Every household should live from its own fields and herds with gathering, fishing and hunting to eke out its resources, and with labour migration or a modicum of produce sales to provide for clothing and other cash requirements. Everyone is aware that this is an ideal, and that it is often necessary to turn to others for assistance. It is generally admitted that they will not be eager to give and that they must be forced to share.

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Valley Tonga are expert in exerting pressure, as anyone who has been subject to their begging must admit. They beg for food and for other goods. The man who wishes to keep his property for his own use can do so only by a judicious secrecy. Those who asked me to purchase supplies for them usually asked to store the purchases in my tent to be drawn upon as needed. If I refused, they would remove the goods to their granaries under cover of darkness, hoping thus to escape the vigilance of their neighbours. If discovered, they were visited by petitioners intent upon receiving a share. One may not refuse a request outright; this is the height of discourtesy. Instead it is proper to say, 'I

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have none', but this is done the more easily when there is no evidence that one is lying.

Begging is usually phrased in terms of kinship obligations, the petitioner including a statement of the relationship in his request. 54 In Middle River region, I had a quasi-kinship position based on the fact that years before the Plateau Tonga had playfully allocated me to a clan and a father's clan. Almost everyone could therefore address me as a fellow clansman, a child of the clan, a grandmother through clan, an affine, or as a clan joking partner. A petitioner would usually validate his request in terms of some such relationship, though the few who could not would justify their requests in terms of our being fellow age-mates or single women or having some other attribute in common. Each was convinced that he had the right to extort what he could, but the most persistent were those who could claim to belong to my father's clan. When I commented on this, there was general agreement that the father's lineage are the most difficult to evade. Only then come lineage mates. Still even more distant relatives urge their claims and it is the lucky and hardy person who is able to retain a hoard of goods.

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